

UPSC GS-II POLITY

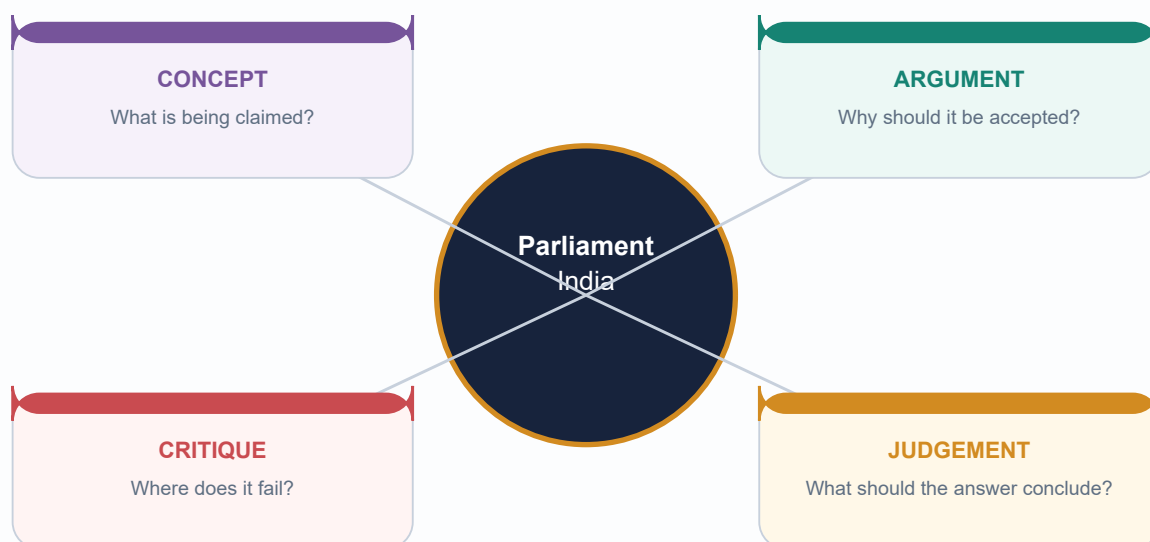
Parliament of India

Integrated Basic + Advanced Course

13 deep-learning modules | Articles 79-122 and Parliamentary Committees

Bicameral structure, legislative procedure, devices of control, committees and Mains frameworks

Prepared from the verified Polity knowledge base (Laxmikant Ch. 22-23) and the completed guided session



Facts from official sources | Inferences clearly marked | No fabricated data

HIGH UPSC RELEVANCE

HIGH

1. Composition of Parliament (Article 79)

GS-II Polity -
Union Legislature

NEWS TRIGGER

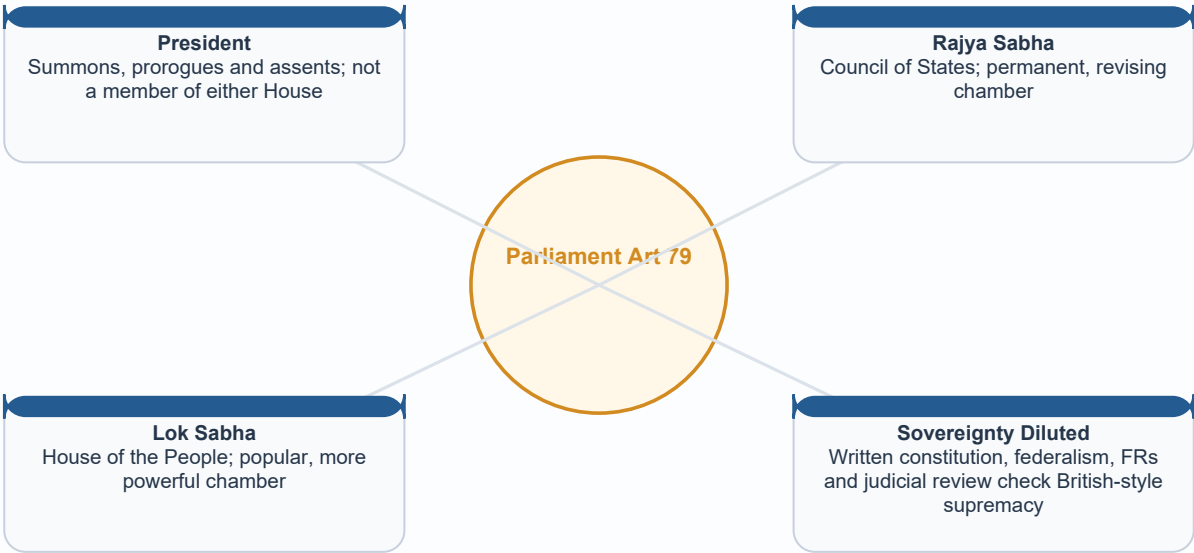
The 2024 GS-II Mains question on the growth of the cabinet system marginalising parliamentary supremacy makes the exact constitutional anatomy of Parliament a recurring examiner favourite.

INTRO & ORIGIN

Article 79 defines Parliament as the President plus the Rajya Sabha (Council of States) and the Lok Sabha (House of the People). The President is not a member of either House but is constitutionally integral: without presidential summons, prorogation and assent, Parliament cannot function or legislate.

India borrowed the parliamentary form from Britain, but British parliamentary sovereignty is deliberately diluted here by a written Constitution, federalism, Fundamental Rights and judicial review.

ANATOMY OF PARLIAMENT



KEY DATA

Feature	Rajya Sabha	Lok Sabha
Nature	Permanent, never dissolved	5-year term, dissolvable
Max strength	250 (238 elected + 12 nominated)	550 (530 states + 20 UTs)
Sanctioned/elected strength	245 sanctioned	543 elected
Election method	Indirect - Single Transferable Vote by state MLAs	Direct - First-Past-The-Post, adult franchise
Nominated members	12 by President (art, literature, science, social service)	None - Anglo-Indian nomination abolished by 104th Amendment

STATIC THEORY

- Parliament is a composite institution; the President's role is formal but indispensable for the legislative cycle to begin and end.
- The Rajya Sabha represents the federal principle - the states as political units - while the Lok Sabha represents the people directly.
- British parliamentary sovereignty assumed no higher law could override Parliament; India rejects this through a supreme, justiciable Constitution.
- Judicial review, Fundamental Rights and basic structure doctrine together transform Parliament from a sovereign body into a constitutionally limited legislature.

MEMORY HOOK

PARLIAMENT = PRESIDENT + RAJYA SABHA + LOK SABHA, never sovereign like Westminster

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Article 79 is the sole constitutional basis for the composition of Parliament.
2. The President assents to, or withholds assent from, every bill passed by both Houses.
3. The 104th Amendment (2019) abolished the Anglo-Indian nomination to the Lok Sabha.
4. Judicial review and the basic structure doctrine limit Parliament's law-making power.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Parliament consists only of the Rajya Sabha and Lok Sabha.

CORRECT: Parliament under Article 79 also includes the President, who is not a member but is constitutionally integral.

WRONG: India follows unqualified British-style parliamentary sovereignty.

CORRECT: India dilutes that sovereignty through a written constitution, federalism, Fundamental Rights and judicial review.

MAINS ANGLE

Use the composite definition of Parliament to argue that Indian parliamentary supremacy was always a qualified, constitutionally bounded form, distinct from British sovereignty.

STUDY LINK

Parliamentary System -> Art 79 | Judicial Review -> Basic Structure

HIGH

2. Rajya Sabha and Lok Sabha: Deeper Comparison

GS-II Polity -
Bicameralism

NEWS TRIGGER

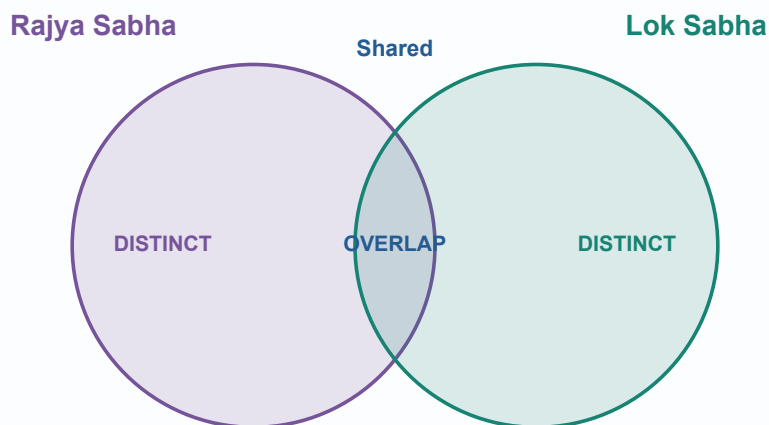
Debates on whether the Rajya Sabha remains an effective revising chamber, or merely delays government business, keep bicameral design in the news.

INTRO & ORIGIN

The two Houses are built on opposite logics: the Rajya Sabha values continuity and federal representation through staggered retirement, while the Lok Sabha values direct accountability to the electorate through periodic dissolution.

Retirement of one-third of Rajya Sabha members every two years ensures the House is never dissolved, giving Parliament institutional memory even when the Lok Sabha is dissolved or under caretaker rule.

RAJYA SABHA AND LOK SABHA COMPARED



Rajya Sabha

- Six-year individual term
- One-third retire every two years
- Represents states as federal units
- Vice-President is ex-officio Chairman

Shared

- Both are Houses of Parliament
- Both scrutinise ordinary legislation
- Quorum is one-tenth of total strength

Lok Sabha

- Five-year House term
- Whole House dissolves together
- Represents the people directly
- Speaker elected from among members

Permanence versus popular accountability is the structural key to every bicameral comparison question.

STATIC THEORY

- Quorum for both Houses is one-tenth of total membership: fifty-five for the Lok Sabha and twenty-five for the Rajya Sabha.
- The Rajya Sabha's permanence allows continuity of business and expertise even when the Lok Sabha is dissolved.
- The Lok Sabha's direct election and dissolvability make it the more powerful House in matters of confidence and money bills.
- Union Territories with legislatures - Delhi, Puducherry and Jammu and Kashmir - alone send members to the Rajya Sabha through an electoral college.

MEMORY HOOK

RS = permanence and federal voice | LS = popular mandate and dissolvability

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Quorum is fifty-five members in the Lok Sabha and twenty-five in the Rajya Sabha.
2. The Rajya Sabha never dissolves; only one-third of its members retire every two years.
3. The Lok Sabha can be extended by one year at a time during a national emergency, up to six months after the emergency ends.
4. The Vice-President chairs the Rajya Sabha ex-officio; the Speaker is elected by Lok Sabha members.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Both Houses retire completely at the same time.

CORRECT: Only the Lok Sabha dissolves as a whole; the Rajya Sabha retires one-third of its members every two years.

WRONG: The Rajya Sabha is a weaker, largely ceremonial House.

CORRECT: It is co-equal in ordinary legislation and exclusively empowered in some federal and service matters, though weaker on money bills and confidence.

MAINS ANGLE

Assess whether the Rajya Sabha's permanence and federal character are being eroded by the growing use of the money-bill route to bypass it.

STUDY LINK

Federal System -> Bicameralism | Parliament
-> Money Bill Route

HIGH

3. Delimitation, Seat Freeze and the Anglo-Indian Nomination

GS-II Polity - Representation

NEWS TRIGGER

The post-2026 census and delimitation question is one of the most politically sensitive federal issues, driving the recurring North-South seat-share debate.

INTRO & ORIGIN

Parliament has repeatedly frozen or deferred delimitation to prevent states that controlled population growth from losing legislative representation relative to faster-growing states.

TIMELINE

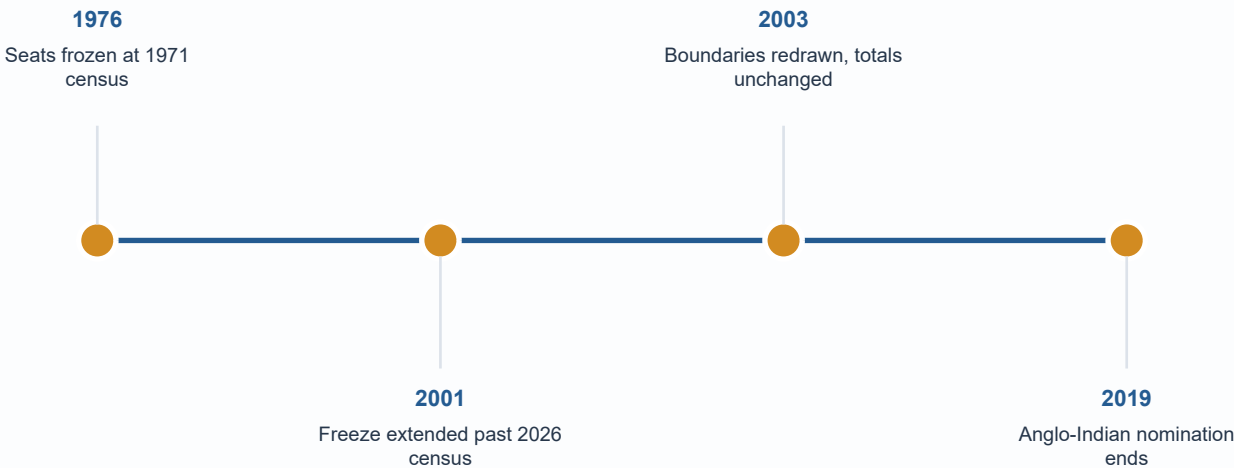
1976 — 42nd Amendment freezes Lok Sabha seat allocation at the 1971 census, effective till 2000.

2001 — 84th Amendment defers readjustment until the first census taken after 2026 is published.

2003 — 87th Amendment allows redrawing constituencies on the 2001 census without changing state seat totals.

2019 — 104th Amendment abolishes the Anglo-Indian nomination to the Lok Sabha and state assemblies.

THE DELIMITATION FREEZE IN FOUR MOVES



KEY DATA

Amendment	Year	Effect
42nd Amendment	1976	Freezes seat allocation at the 1971 census
84th Amendment	2001	Defers readjustment until first post-2026 census figures are published
87th Amendment	2003	Redraws constituencies on 2001 census; state totals unchanged
104th Amendment	2019	Abolishes Anglo-Indian nomination in Lok Sabha and assemblies

STATIC THEORY

- The freeze rewards states that achieved earlier demographic transition by protecting their existing seat share.
- Readjustment does not restart automatically in 2026; it remains deferred until the relevant figures of the first census taken after 2026 are published.
- SC and ST seats are reserved on the basis of population ratio; India does not use separate electorates for them.
- The freeze-and-defer strategy shows Parliament using its amending power to manage federal political risk rather than leaving representation to arithmetic alone.

MEMORY HOOK

1976 FREEZE | 2001 DEFER | 2003 REDRAW | 2019 ANGLO-INDIAN ENDS

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. The seat freeze currently rests on the 1971 census, not any later census.
2. Readjustment is tied to the first census taken after 2026, not to the year 2026 itself.
3. The 87th Amendment changed constituency boundaries but not the total number of seats per state.
4. Anglo-Indian nomination to the Lok Sabha and state assemblies no longer exists after the 104th Amendment.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Delimitation will automatically resume in the year 2026.

CORRECT: It remains deferred until the relevant figures of the first census taken after 2026 have been published.

WRONG: The 104th Amendment extended Anglo-Indian nomination.

CORRECT: It abolished the nomination; the 95th Amendment had earlier extended it to 2020.

MAINS ANGLE

Examine the delimitation freeze as an instrument of cooperative federalism that balances demographic representation against regional political stability.

STUDY LINK

Election Commission -> Delimitation |
Centre-State Relations -> Federal Balance

HIGH

4. Presiding Officers: Speaker, Deputy Speaker and Rajya Sabha Chairman

GS-II Polity -
Parliamentary
Offices

NEWS TRIGGER

The Deputy Speaker's post has remained vacant since 2018, a recurring constitutional-propriety debate about whether a constitutionally named office can be left unfilled indefinitely.

INTRO & ORIGIN

The Speaker is the Lok Sabha's own chosen presiding officer and its final interpreter of the Constitution and Rules within the House, while the Rajya Sabha is chaired by the Vice-President, who is not even a member of that House.

KEY DATA

Feature	Speaker (Lok Sabha)	Chairman (Rajya Sabha)
Who holds office	Elected by Lok Sabha from its members	Vice-President, ex-officio, not a member
Removal	Effective majority, 14 days' notice	Removed only by removal from Vice-Presidency
On dissolution	Continues till new Lok Sabha meets	Not applicable - Rajya Sabha never dissolves
Key power	Final decision on whether a bill is a Money Bill (Art 110)	Presides over Rajya Sabha; no Money Bill certification role

WHEN DOES THE SPEAKER VACATE OFFICE?**STATIC THEORY**

- The Speaker's decision on whether a bill is a Money Bill is final under Article 110, though constitutional courts retain narrow review for illegality or constitutional misuse.
- The Speaker presides over joint sittings under Article 108 and exercises a casting vote in the event of a tie.
- Anti-defection disqualification decisions rest with the Speaker or Chairman, subject to judicial review (Kihoto Hollohan, 1992).
- The Deputy Chairman of the Rajya Sabha is elected from among its own members, unlike the Chairman.

MEMORY HOOK

SPEAKER decides Money Bills; **VICE-PRESIDENT** chairs Rajya Sabha without being its member

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. The Speaker does not vacate office merely because the Lok Sabha is dissolved.
2. The Speaker's salary is charged on the Consolidated Fund, insulating it from annual vote.
3. Kihoto Hollohan (1992) subjected the Speaker's anti-defection decisions to judicial review.
4. The Deputy Speaker's post has remained vacant since 2018.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: The Speaker vacates office the moment the Lok Sabha is dissolved.

CORRECT: The Speaker continues in office until the newly constituted Lok Sabha meets.

WRONG: The Rajya Sabha Chairman is elected from among its own members.

CORRECT: The Vice-President is the ex-officio Chairman; only the Deputy Chairman is elected from Rajya Sabha members.

MAINS ANGLE

Discuss whether a vacant Deputy Speaker's post since 2018 undermines the constitutional design of institutional continuity in the Lok Sabha.

STUDY LINK

Anti-Defection Law -> Speaker's Role |
Parliamentary System -> Presiding Officers

HIGH

5. Sessions, Summoning and Termination of Business

GS-II Polity -
Parliamentary
Procedure

NEWS TRIGGER

Shrinking sitting days across Budget, Monsoon and Winter sessions fuel recurring concern about Parliament's declining deliberative capacity.

INTRO & ORIGIN

The President must summon each House so that the gap between two sessions never exceeds six months, guaranteeing Parliament meets at least twice a year.

India follows a three-session convention - Budget, Monsoon and Winter - though the Constitution itself only fixes the maximum gap, not the number or names of sessions.

KEY DATA

Term	Meaning	Who Acts
Adjournment	Suspends a sitting; pending business is unaffected	Presiding officer
Adjournment sine die	Terminates a sitting indefinitely	Presiding officer
Prorogation	Ends a session; pending notices lapse but pending bills survive	President
Dissolution	Ends the life of the Lok Sabha only	President; Rajya Sabha never dissolves
Lame-duck session	Last session of an outgoing Lok Sabha	N/A

FROM SUMMONS TO DISSOLUTION

STATIC THEORY

- Quorum to transact business is one-tenth of total membership in either House.
- Prorogation is a presidential act ending a session, distinct from adjournment, which a presiding officer orders to suspend a sitting.
- A prorogued session's pending notices lapse, but bills already introduced do not lapse merely because of prorogation.
- The three-session convention is a working practice, not an explicit constitutional mandate beyond the six-month gap rule.

MEMORY HOOK

ADJOURN a sitting | **PROROGUE** a session | **DISSOLVE** only the Lok Sabha

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. The maximum permissible gap between two sessions of Parliament is six months.
2. Prorogation is exercised by the President, while adjournment is exercised by the presiding officer.
3. The Rajya Sabha, being permanent, is never dissolved.
4. A lame-duck session is the final session of an outgoing Lok Sabha before a new one is constituted.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Prorogation and adjournment are exercised by the same authority.

CORRECT: Prorogation is a presidential act ending a session; adjournment is ordered by the presiding officer to suspend a sitting.

WRONG: Dissolution ends the life of both Houses of Parliament.

CORRECT: Dissolution applies only to the Lok Sabha; the Rajya Sabha is never dissolved.

MAINS ANGLE

Evaluate whether declining sitting days and frequent disruptions are eroding Parliament's deliberative and law-making role.

STUDY LINK

Parliamentary System -> Sessions |
Parliament -> Legislative Procedure

HIGH

6. Devices of Parliamentary Control: Question Hour, Zero Hour and Motions

GS-II Polity -
Executive
Accountability

NEWS TRIGGER

Frequent disruptions of Question Hour and the informal use of Zero Hour to raise urgent matters are recurring themes in assessments of Parliament's oversight function.

INTRO & ORIGIN

Parliament controls the executive daily through devices ranging from formal Question Hour to informal Zero Hour and a family of motions that can censure the government or test its confidence.

THE TOOLKIT OF PARLIAMENTARY CONTROL

Devices of Control

Question Hour Starred, unstarred and short-notice questions; the first hour of a sitting	Zero Hour Informal Indian innovation since 1962; not mentioned in the Rules
Adjournment Motion Censures government on an urgent matter; only in the Lok Sabha; needs 50 members	No-Confidence Motion Tests majority support; only in the Lok Sabha; needs 50 members

KEY DATA

Motion	House	Purpose
Adjournment Motion	Lok Sabha only	Censures government over an urgent public matter
No-Confidence Motion	Lok Sabha only	Tests whether the government retains majority support
Censure Motion	Either House	Criticises government policy without necessarily seeking resignation
Calling-Attention Motion	Either House	Draws the minister's attention to an urgent matter of public importance
Cut Motions	Lok Sabha (demands for grants)	Policy Cut (Re. 1), Economy Cut, Token Cut (Rs. 100)

STATIC THEORY

- Question Hour is governed by the Rules of Procedure; Zero Hour is an informal practice that has no rule-book basis.
- The Adjournment Motion and No-Confidence Motion are exclusive to the Lok Sabha because they concern executive accountability to the popular House.
- Cut motions on demands for grants are the classic route through which the Lok Sabha exercises its financial control over the executive.
- Together these devices convert daily parliamentary sittings into a continuous check on ministerial conduct, beyond formal legislation.

MEMORY HOOK

QUESTION HOUR is in the Rules; ZERO HOUR is India's own informal innovation since 1962

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Zero Hour has operated in Indian parliamentary practice since 1962 without formal rule-book recognition.
2. Both the Adjournment Motion and the No-Confidence Motion require the support of fifty members and operate only in the Lok Sabha.
3. Token Cut Motions seek a symbolic reduction of Rs. 100 in a demand for grants.
4. Calling-Attention Motions can be moved in either House, unlike the Adjournment or No-Confidence Motions.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Zero Hour is formally defined in the Rules of Procedure.

CORRECT: Zero Hour is an informal practice since 1962; only Question Hour has rule-book status.

WRONG: A No-Confidence Motion can be moved in the Rajya Sabha.

CORRECT: It can be moved only in the Lok Sabha, which alone controls the government's survival.

MAINS ANGLE

Assess whether frequent disruptions of Question Hour and the growing informal reliance on Zero Hour weaken Parliament's routine oversight of the executive.

STUDY LINK

Parliamentary System -> Executive Accountability | Parliament -> Financial Committees

HIGH

7. Lapsing of Bills on Dissolution of the Lok Sabha

GS-II Polity -
Legislative
Procedure

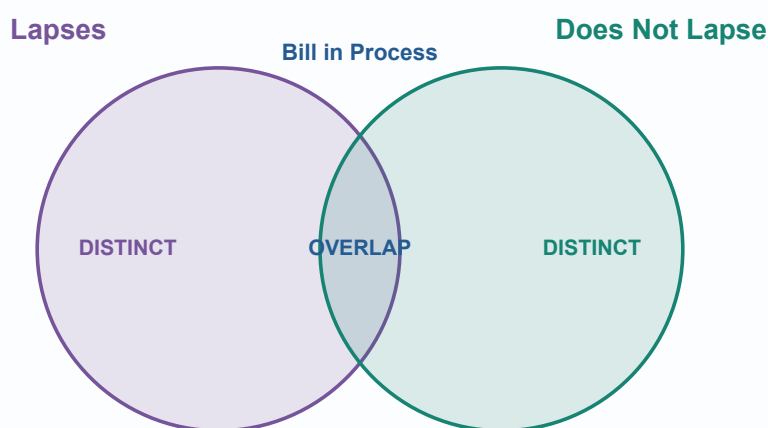
NEWS TRIGGER

Every general election revives questions about which pending bills survive into the new Lok Sabha and which must be reintroduced from scratch.

INTRO & ORIGIN

Dissolution ends the life of the Lok Sabha, but its effect on pending legislative business depends on precisely where a bill stood in the legislative process at that moment.

WHAT SURVIVES DISSOLUTION OF THE LOK SABHA



Lapses

- Bill pending in the Lok Sabha
- Bill passed by the Lok Sabha but pending in the Rajya Sabha

Bill in Process

- Bill introduced in Parliament before dissolution
- Legislative status frozen at the moment of dissolution

Does Not Lapse

- Bill pending in the Rajya Sabha but not yet passed by the Lok Sabha
- Bill passed by both Houses but awaiting presidential assent
- Bill returned by the President for reconsideration
- Bill for which a joint sitting was already notified

The Rajya Sabha's permanence is the reason bills pending only there, or already through both Houses, survive dissolution.

STATIC THEORY

- The general rule is that only bills still within the Lok Sabha's own control lapse on its dissolution.
- A bill pending in the Rajya Sabha alone does not lapse because that House is never dissolved.
- Bills already passed by both Houses and merely awaiting presidential assent are unaffected by a Lok Sabha dissolution.
- A notified joint sitting protects a bill from lapsing even if the Lok Sabha dissolves before the sitting is held.

MEMORY HOOK

LOK SABHA CONTROL LAPSES | RAJYA SABHA CONTROL SURVIVES

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. A bill pending in the Lok Sabha lapses automatically on its dissolution.
2. A bill passed by the Lok Sabha but still pending in the Rajya Sabha also lapses on dissolution.
3. A bill pending only in the Rajya Sabha, without having been passed by the Lok Sabha, does not lapse.
4. A bill awaiting only the President's assent survives a Lok Sabha dissolution.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: All pending bills lapse when the Lok Sabha is dissolved.

CORRECT: Only bills still within the Lok Sabha's control lapse; bills pending solely in the Rajya Sabha or awaiting assent survive.

WRONG: A notified joint sitting is cancelled by dissolution.

CORRECT: A bill for which a joint sitting has already been notified does not lapse on dissolution.

MAINS ANGLE

Use the lapsing rules to illustrate how the Rajya Sabha's permanence provides legislative continuity that the dissolvable Lok Sabha cannot.

STUDY LINK

Parliament -> Bicameralism | Parliament -> Legislative Procedure

HIGH**8. Ordinary Bill Procedure and the Joint Sitting**

GS-II Polity -
Legislative
Procedure

NEWS TRIGGER

Only three joint sittings have ever been held in India's parliamentary history, making the deadlock-resolution mechanism itself a high-value, low-frequency exam fact.

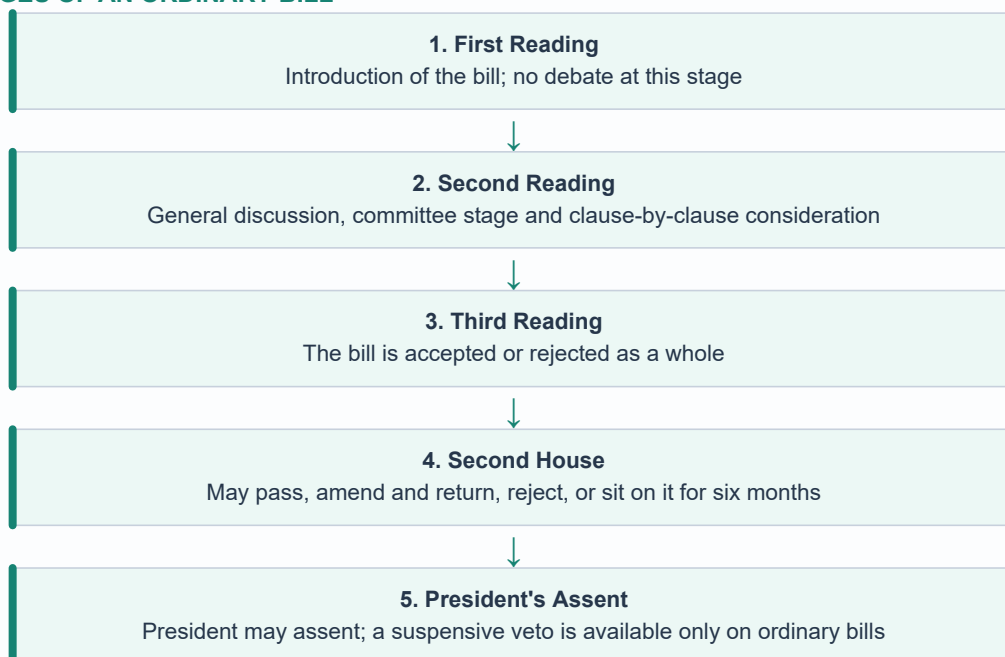
INTRO & ORIGIN

An ordinary bill moves through three readings in its originating House before crossing to the second House, which may pass, amend, reject or simply sit on it for six months.

KEY DATA

Joint Sitting	Year	Subject
First joint sitting	1961	Dowry Prohibition Bill
Second joint sitting	1978	Banking Services Commission (Repeal) Bill
Third joint sitting	2002	Prevention of Terrorism Bill (POTA)

FIVE STAGES OF AN ORDINARY BILL



STATIC THEORY

- A deadlock arises when the second House rejects the bill, proposes amendments the first House will not accept, or fails to act within six months.
- Article 108 empowers the President to summon a joint sitting to resolve such a deadlock, presided over by the Speaker of the Lok Sabha.
- Only three joint sittings have ever been held, underlining how rare an actual bicameral deadlock is in practice.
- The President's suspensive veto - returning a bill once for reconsideration - applies only to ordinary bills, not money bills.

MEMORY HOOK

5 STAGES, then JOINT SITTING (Art 108) if deadlocked - only 3 ever held

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. The three joint sittings held so far concerned the Dowry Prohibition Bill (1961), the Banking Service Commission Bill (1978) and POTA (2002).
2. A joint sitting is presided over by the Speaker of the Lok Sabha, not the Rajya Sabha Chairman.
3. The second House can sit on an ordinary bill for up to six months before a deadlock is deemed to arise.
4. The President's suspensive veto lets an ordinary bill be returned once for reconsideration.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: A joint sitting can be summoned for a money bill.

CORRECT: No joint-sitting provision exists for money bills; Article 108 applies only to ordinary bills.

WRONG: The Rajya Sabha Chairman presides over a joint sitting.

CORRECT: The Speaker of the Lok Sabha presides over every joint sitting.

MAINS ANGLE

Discuss why joint sittings remain a rarely used constitutional safety valve, and what this reveals about bicameral cooperation in Indian legislative practice.

STUDY LINK

Parliament -> Money Bill vs Ordinary Bill |
Parliament -> Presiding Officers

HIGH

9. Money Bill, Financial Bill and the Certification Controversy

GS-II Polity -
Financial
Legislation

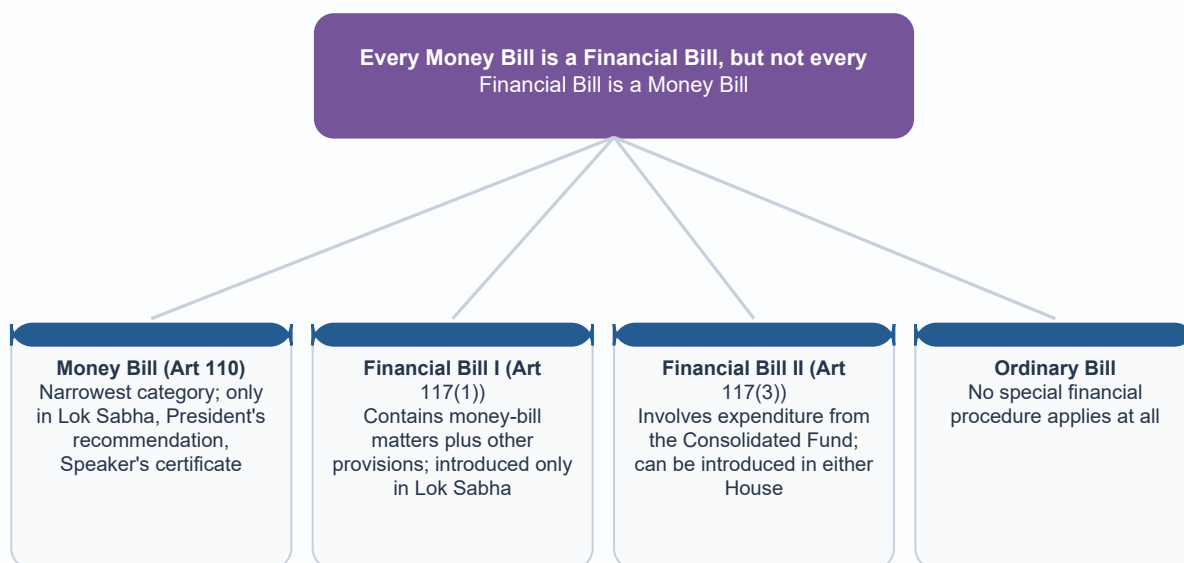
NEWS TRIGGER

Certifying the Aadhaar Act and later Finance Act amendments as money bills triggered litigation before the Supreme Court, keeping the money-bill route a live constitutional controversy.

INTRO & ORIGIN

A money bill under Article 110 can be introduced only in the Lok Sabha, on the President's recommendation, and the Rajya Sabha can merely recommend changes that the Lok Sabha is free to reject.

THE FINANCIAL BILLS HIERARCHY



KEY DATA

Feature	Money Bill (Art 110)	Ordinary Bill
Where introduced	Only Lok Sabha, on President's recommendation	Either House
Rajya Sabha's power	Cannot reject or amend; only recommends; must return in 14 days	Equal power to amend or reject
Speaker's certificate	Required; Article 110 calls it final, subject to narrow judicial review	Not applicable
Joint sitting	No provision at all	Available under Article 108
President's power	Assent or withhold assent; cannot return	Can return once for reconsideration

STATIC THEORY

- Article 110 lists the exclusive subjects that make a bill a money bill: taxation, borrowing, the Consolidated Fund and similar matters.
- The Speaker's certificate on whether a bill is a money bill is constitutionally final, but courts have kept open a narrow review for illegality or constitutional misuse.
- Certifying wide-ranging legislation as a money bill lets the government bypass the Rajya Sabha entirely, since that House cannot amend or reject it.
- The Aadhaar Act and later Finance Act amendments certified as money bills were challenged in Rojer Mathew and linked to concerns raised in Puttaswamy.

MEMORY HOOK

MONEY BILL □ **FINANCIAL BILL I** □ **FINANCIAL BILL II** - only Money Bills bypass the Rajya Sabha

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. A money bill can be introduced only in the Lok Sabha, on the President's recommendation.
2. The Rajya Sabha must return a money bill within fourteen days, with only recommendations, not amendments.
3. There is no joint-sitting provision for money bills, unlike ordinary bills under Article 108.
4. The Speaker's money-bill certification has been challenged in litigation such as Rojer Mathew, though it remains constitutionally final subject to narrow review.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: A money bill may be introduced in either House.

CORRECT: It can be introduced only in the Lok Sabha, on the President's recommendation.

WRONG: The Rajya Sabha can amend a money bill.

CORRECT: It can only recommend changes, which the Lok Sabha may accept or reject.

MAINS ANGLE

Critically examine the money-bill route as a mechanism for bypassing the Rajya Sabha, and evaluate whether it erodes bicameral scrutiny of major legislation.

STUDY LINK

Supreme Court -> Judicial Review of Money Bills | Parliament -> Ordinary Bill Procedure

HIGH

10. Financial Committees: PAC, Estimates Committee and CoPU

GS-II Polity -
Financial
Accountability

NEWS TRIGGER

The Public Accounts Committee's scrutiny of CAG reports remains central to every major audit controversy involving government spending.

INTRO & ORIGIN

Three financial committees divide the work of scrutinising public money: the Public Accounts Committee examines what was already spent, the Estimates Committee examines what is proposed to be spent, and the Committee on Public Undertakings examines how public sector enterprises perform.

THREE FINANCIAL COMMITTEES, THREE ROLES

Financial Scrutiny

PAC Post-mortem examination of CAG reports on money already spent	Estimates Committee Continuous economy committee; examines budget estimates before spending
Committee on Public Undertakings Examines performance of public sector enterprises, born from the Krishna Menon Committee, 1964	

KEY DATA

Committee	Members	Rajya Sabha Representation	Chairman
Public Accounts Committee	22 (15 Lok Sabha + 7 Rajya Sabha)	Yes	From the Opposition, by convention since 1967
Estimates Committee	30	No - Lok Sabha only	Ruling party member
Committee on Public Undertakings	22 (15 Lok Sabha + 7 Rajya Sabha)	Yes	Lok Sabha member

STATIC THEORY

- The PAC's convention of an Opposition chairman, followed since 1967, is meant to keep executive scrutiny independent of the ruling party.
- The Estimates Committee is Lok Sabha-only because it deals with money matters that fall within that House's special financial competence.
- The Committee on Public Undertakings extends financial accountability beyond the annual budget cycle into ongoing enterprise performance.
- None of these three committees can include a serving minister as a member, preserving the separation between the executive and its overseers.

MEMORY HOOK

PAC looks BACK at CAG reports | ESTIMATES looks FORWARD at the budget | CoPU watches PSUs

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. The Public Accounts Committee has been chaired by an Opposition member since 1967.
2. The Estimates Committee, with thirty members, draws exclusively from the Lok Sabha.
3. The Committee on Public Undertakings traces its origin to the Krishna Menon Committee of 1964.
4. Ministers cannot be members of any of the three financial committees.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: The Estimates Committee includes Rajya Sabha members.

CORRECT: It is composed entirely of thirty Lok Sabha members.

WRONG: The Public Accounts Committee is chaired by a ruling-party member.

CORRECT: By convention since 1967, it is chaired by a member of the Opposition.

MAINS ANGLE

Evaluate the effectiveness of financial committees as instruments of legislative control over public expenditure, in the face of executive dominance.

STUDY LINK

CAG -> Audit Reports | Parliament -> Departmentally Related Standing Committees

HIGH

11. Departmentally Related Standing Committees and Ad Hoc Committees

GS-II Polity -
Legislative
Scrutiny

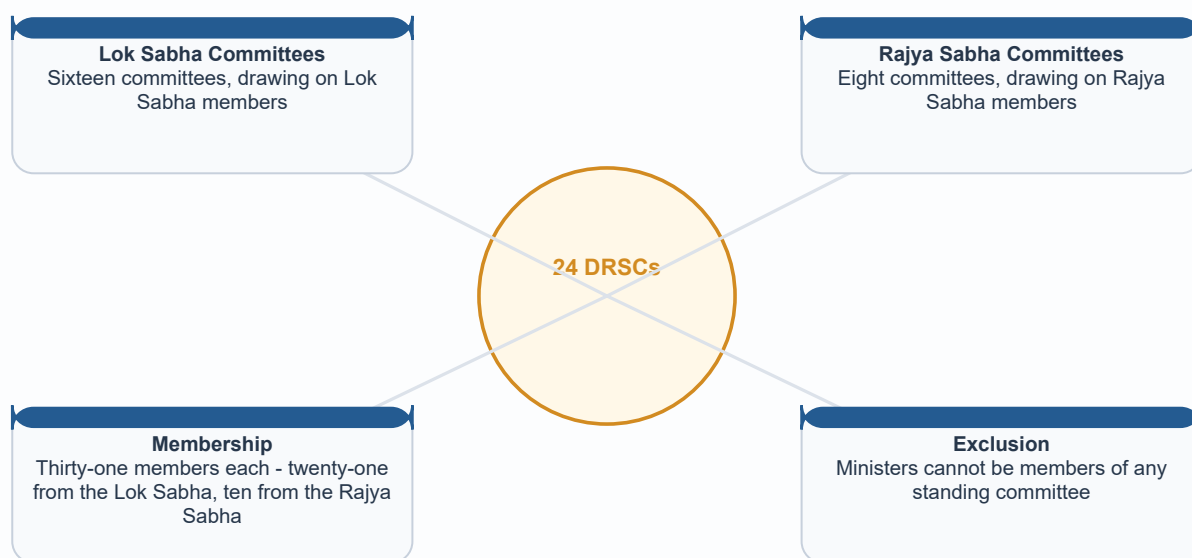
NEWS TRIGGER

Standing committees are frequently described as "mini-parliaments" whenever a major bill is referred to them for detailed, less adversarial scrutiny than the floor of the House allows.

INTRO & ORIGIN

Twenty-four Departmentally Related Standing Committees examine demands for grants, bills and annual reports across every ministry, providing continuous, specialised executive oversight beyond the annual budget session.

STRUCTURE OF THE STANDING COMMITTEE SYSTEM



KEY DATA

Committee Type	Examples	Function
Departmentally Related Standing Committees	24 committees across all ministries	Demands for grants, bills, annual reports
Select and Joint Committees	Formed on specific bills	Detailed clause-by-clause scrutiny of a referred bill
Joint Parliamentary Committees	Ad hoc, subject-specific	Investigate major issues referred by Parliament
Consultative Committees	Chaired by a minister	Not parliamentary committees; informal consultation only

STATIC THEORY

- DRSCs allow less adversarial, more technical scrutiny of legislation and budgets than the full floor of either House.
- The exclusion of ministers from standing committee membership preserves a clear line between the executive and the body scrutinising it.
- Consultative committees are chaired by a minister and are therefore not classified as parliamentary committees at all.
- Referring a bill to a standing or select committee is one way Parliament slows down legislation to permit expert and stakeholder input.

MEMORY HOOK

24 DRSCs = 16 LS + 8 RS committees, 31 members each (21 LS + 10 RS)

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. There are twenty-four Departmentally Related Standing Committees, sixteen under the Lok Sabha and eight under the Rajya Sabha.
2. Each standing committee has thirty-one members: twenty-one from the Lok Sabha and ten from the Rajya Sabha.
3. Ministers are barred from membership of these committees.
4. Consultative committees, chaired by a minister, are not parliamentary committees.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Consultative committees are a type of parliamentary committee.

CORRECT: They are chaired by a minister and are explicitly not parliamentary committees.

WRONG: Standing committees can include a sitting minister as a member.

CORRECT: Ministers are excluded from membership of all standing committees.

MAINS ANGLE

Assess standing committees as "mini-parliaments" that strengthen legislative scrutiny, and discuss whether declining bill-referral rates weaken this function.

STUDY LINK

Parliament -> Financial Committees |
Parliament -> Legislative Procedure

HIGH

12. Women's Reservation and the Federal Representation Debate

GS-II Polity -
Representation
Reform

NEWS TRIGGER

The Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam (106th Amendment, 2023) reserves one-third of seats for women, but its operational start remains tied to a sequence of unmet constitutional conditions.

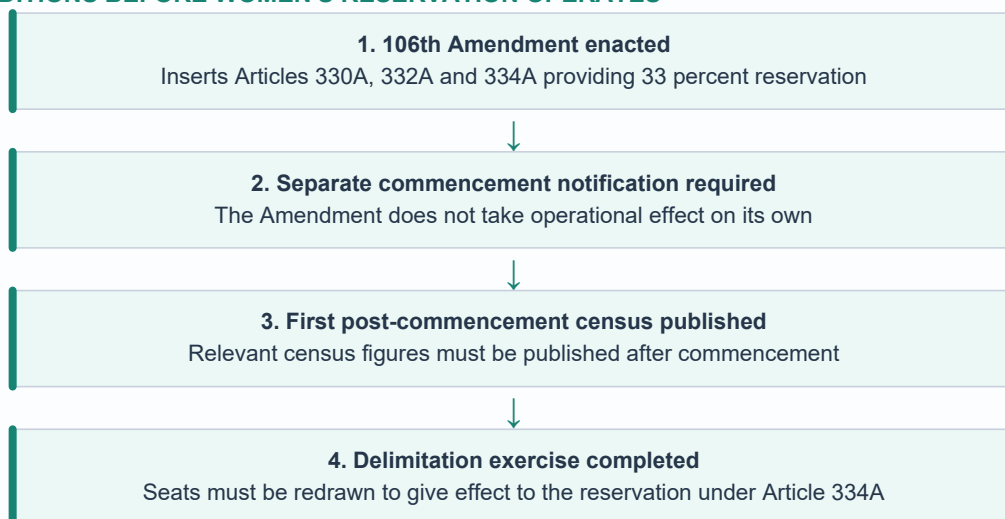
INTRO & ORIGIN

The 106th Amendment inserts Articles 330A, 332A and 334A to reserve thirty-three percent of seats for women in the Lok Sabha and state assemblies, including within seats already reserved for Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes.

KEY DATA

Element	Status
106th Amendment (2023)	Enacted; inserts Articles 330A, 332A and 334A
Reservation quantum	33 percent, including within SC/ST-reserved seats
Commencement notification	No operational commencement notification located as of the check date
Precondition sequence	Requires post-commencement census figures and delimitation before operation

THE CONDITIONS BEFORE WOMEN'S RESERVATION OPERATES



STATIC THEORY

- The reservation is designed to operate within, not alongside, existing SC and ST seat reservations, so those categories will also gain women-only sub-reservations.
- The Amendment's own text ties its operational start to a separately notified commencement, the relevant post-commencement census and a completed delimitation exercise.
- Because delimitation itself is deferred until the first census after 2026, effective operation of the reservation is necessarily linked to that broader constitutional timeline.
- The reform intersects two live debates at once: gender representation and the federal seat-share consequences of delimitation.

MEMORY HOOK

106th AMENDMENT = 33% reservation, but COMMENCEMENT + CENSUS + DELIMITATION must all occur first

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. The 106th Amendment (2023) is popularly called the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam.
2. It inserts Articles 330A, 332A and 334A into the Constitution.
3. The reservation applies within existing SC and ST reserved seats as well as general seats.
4. As of the verified check date, no operational commencement notification had been located.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Women's reservation took effect immediately upon the 106th Amendment's enactment.

CORRECT: It requires a separate commencement notification, the relevant post-commencement census and completed delimitation.

WRONG: Women's reservation seats are entirely separate from SC/ST reserved seats.

CORRECT: The reservation operates within SC/ST-reserved seats as well as general seats.

MAINS ANGLE

Discuss whether linking women's reservation to a deferred delimitation exercise risks converting a transformative gender reform into an indefinitely postponed promise.

STUDY LINK

Delimitation -> Post-2026 Census |
Fundamental Rights -> Equality and Representation

HIGH

13. UPSC Answer-Writing Framework: Parliament, Cabinet and Reform

GS-II Mains
Polity - Answer
Writing

NEWS TRIGGER

The 2024 GS-II Mains paper directly tested whether growth of the cabinet system has marginalised parliamentary supremacy, making an institutional-counterweight framework essential.

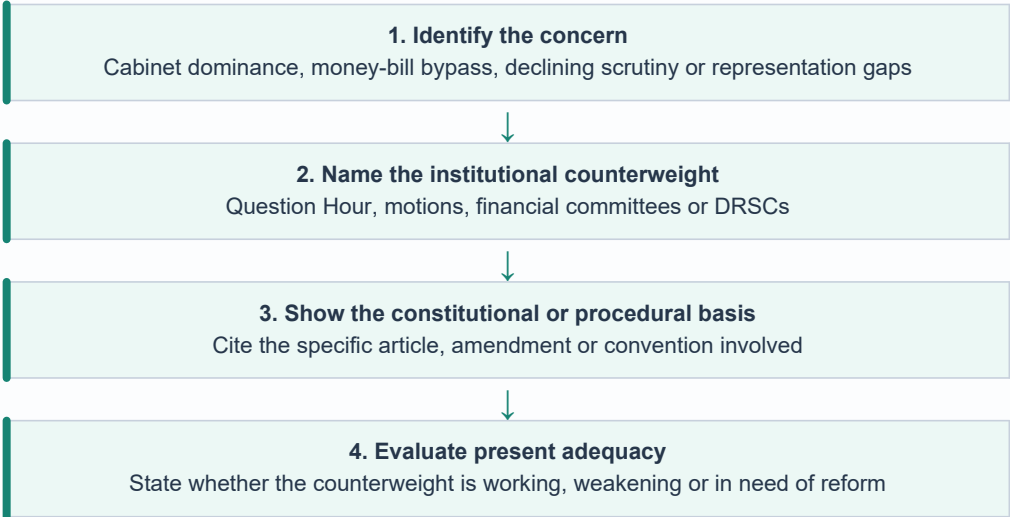
INTRO & ORIGIN

UPSC rarely rewards a bare description of Parliament's structure. A strong answer names the specific institutional counterweight - questions, motions, financial control or committees - that responds to a given governance concern.

KEY DATA

Question Theme	Core Argument	Key Illustration
Cabinet dominance over Parliament	Questions, motions and committees remain the institutional counterweight	Question Hour, No-Confidence Motion, DRSCs
Money-bill route bypassing Rajya Sabha	Certification widens the scope of Article 110 beyond its intended narrow purpose	Aadhaar Act, Rojer Mathew litigation
Committees as mini-parliaments	Standing committees provide technical, less adversarial scrutiny	24 DRSCs, PAC, Estimates Committee
Women's reservation and representation	Reform is transformative in design but conditional in operation	106th Amendment, delimitation linkage

THE FOUR-STEP METHOD FOR PARLIAMENT QUESTIONS



STATIC THEORY

- The examiner's 2024 question on cabinet growth expects candidates to name specific parliamentary tools of accountability, not merely describe the cabinet system.
- A complete answer route links institutional design (Articles and committees) to a live controversy (money-bill certification, vacant Deputy Speaker post, delayed women's reservation).
- Balanced answers avoid both extremes: neither claiming Parliament is powerless before the executive, nor ignoring genuine erosion of bicameral and committee scrutiny.
- Cross-reference is essential: this framework connects directly to the Parliamentary System file for the cabinet-versus-legislature relationship.

MEMORY HOOK**IDENTIFY concern -> NAME counterweight -> CITE basis -> EVALUATE adequacy****MUST-KNOW FACTS**

1. The verified 2024 GS-II Mains question (10 marks, 150 words) asked how growth of the cabinet system has marginalised parliamentary supremacy.
2. Questions, motions, financial control and committees are the standard institutional counterweights to cite in such answers.
3. The complete institutional-counterweight answer route is developed further in the Parliamentary System file.
4. Every reform theme in this module - money bills, committees, women's reservation - has a specific constitutional or amendment basis to cite.

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Describing Parliament's structure alone answers a cabinet-dominance question.**CORRECT:** The answer must name specific institutional counterweights and evaluate whether they still function effectively.**WRONG:** Every reform discussed in this module is already fully operational.**CORRECT:** Several, such as women's reservation, remain conditional on further constitutional steps like delimitation.**MAINS ANGLE**

Model thesis: parliamentary supremacy is preserved not through floor debates alone but through a layered accountability architecture of questions, motions, financial committees and standing committees, which must be defended against both executive bypass and legislative apathy.

STUDY LINK

Parliamentary System -> Cabinet and
Legislature | Parliament -> Committees and
Financial Control